BRAVE OF HEART

In her debut book, **Mansi Choksi** paints a sombre, compelling portrait of three couples who defy all odds to be together in modern India



INDIA PICTURE

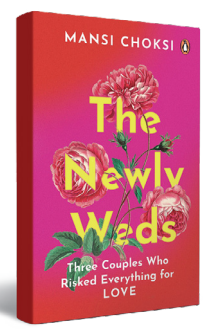
In popular culture, especially Bollywood, there's a sense of urgency that accompanies the act of elopement: couples hatching swift plans to sidestep family diktats or religious restrictions, rounding up their most precious belongings and running away in the dead of night. This wasn't the case with Neetu Rani and Dawinder Singh, a Hindu-Sikh couple living in neighbouring houses in the Kakheri village of Haryana. Two nights after Dawinder dropped off a bottle of sleeping pills for Neetu to spike her parents' food with, he helped her haul four suitcases containing clothes to last a month, old family albums, stuffed animals, and a life-size poster of herself she'd had taken in a professional studio.

"There's a certain lightness that you associate with elopement. Neetu had friendship bands, albums and her clothes had been carefully picked over months. It was hilarious and I was instantly taken in by her. Her personality captured this aspirational quality peculiar to small-town India," says Mansi Choksi, over a video call from Dubai. She first met Neetu and Dawinder in Delhi, where they were seeking shelter with the Love Commandos, a charity group that helped runaway couples and those threatened by honour killings get married legally. Over the next five years, Choksi stayed in touch with them, chronicling their journey for her recently launched debut book, *The Newlyweds*.

Through the journeys of six people over half a decade—there's Monika and Arif, an interfaith couple on the run from right-wing vigilantes, and Reshma and Preethi, a lesbian couple—Choksi attempts to deconstruct love in modern India, albeit one that exists outside big cities. She places their stories within the larger socio-political context of the country, weaving in crucial details of historical events such as the Partition, Section 377, honour killings and narratives like 'love jihad'.

"I wanted to write a book that not only told the story of how young love forms and falls apart, but also how their journeys say something larger about India. Neetu and Dawinder's story illustrates big themes about caste prejudice and the capitalist nature of

THE NEWLYWEDS: THREE COUPLES WHO RISKED EVERYTHING FOR LOVE
By Mansi Choksi
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